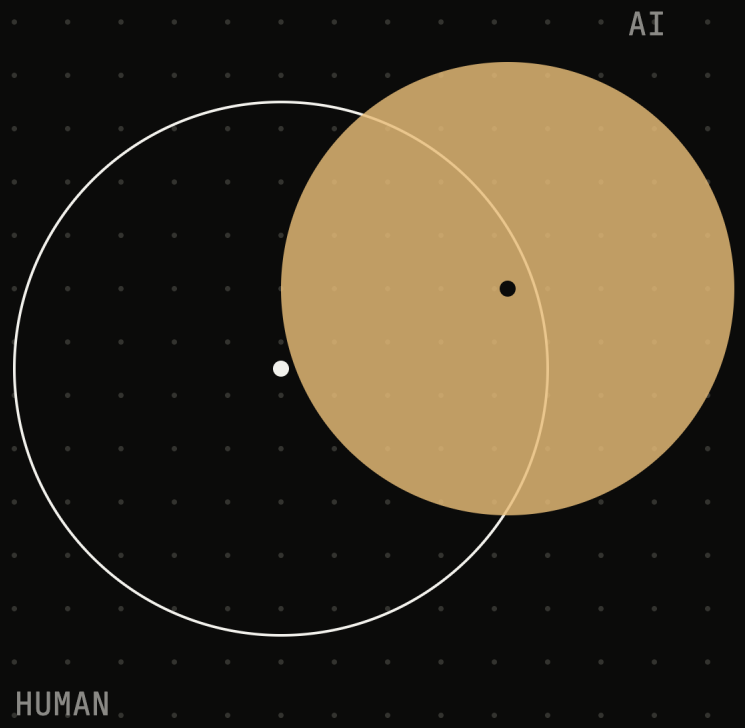
DESIGN · AI · RESEARCH

# DESIGN RESEARCH IN THE AGE OF AI




**Building got cheap. Knowing got expensive.**
On craft and humanity in the age of AI.

By Issac Ting (2026)

WORKSHOP · [EVENT, DATE]

HI, I'M ZAC

# Issac Ting

| | |
|---|---|
| DESIGN | Product designer. About seven years in UX. |
| NOW | Graduate researcher at NYU Tandon. MSc student, COPHEE Lab. |
| INTERESTS | History, and the social side of technology. |

How does technology shape our relationships, with each other and with ourselves?

TONIGHT

# You’ll leave able to

01 Navigate how AI is changing user behaviour, and how teams work.

02 Spot where AI opens doors for design and research, and where it breaks them.

03 Use human craft and empathy as your edge.

04 Turn human-AI research into better products.

THE PLAN

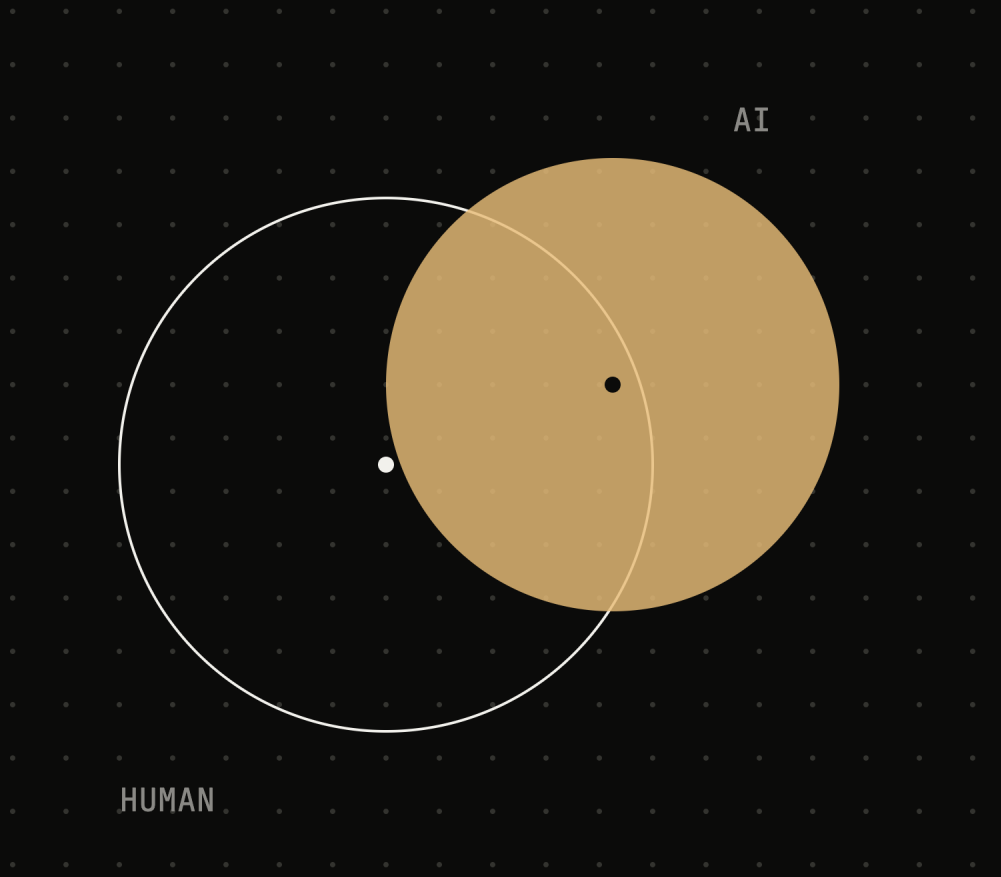
# Three questions

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 01 | Look back | How knowledge travels: the Renaissance, and UX |
| 02 | What AI changed | Trust, and how we work now |
| 03 | What we need | Build better. Then: map your day |

DESIGN · AI · RESEARCH

# Look back

Part 1 · How knowledge travels




By Issac Ting (2026)

6:40–6:55 PM

PART 1 · A RENAISSANCE

# Europe looked back to remake itself

| | |
|---|---|
| 1347–1351 | The Black Death kills a third to a half of Europe, and shakes the old order. |
| 14TH–16TH C. | Scholars and artists turn to Greece and Rome, recovering and translating what had survived. |
| THE RESULT | Not a return to antiquity: new work that built on the classics, and sometimes went further. |

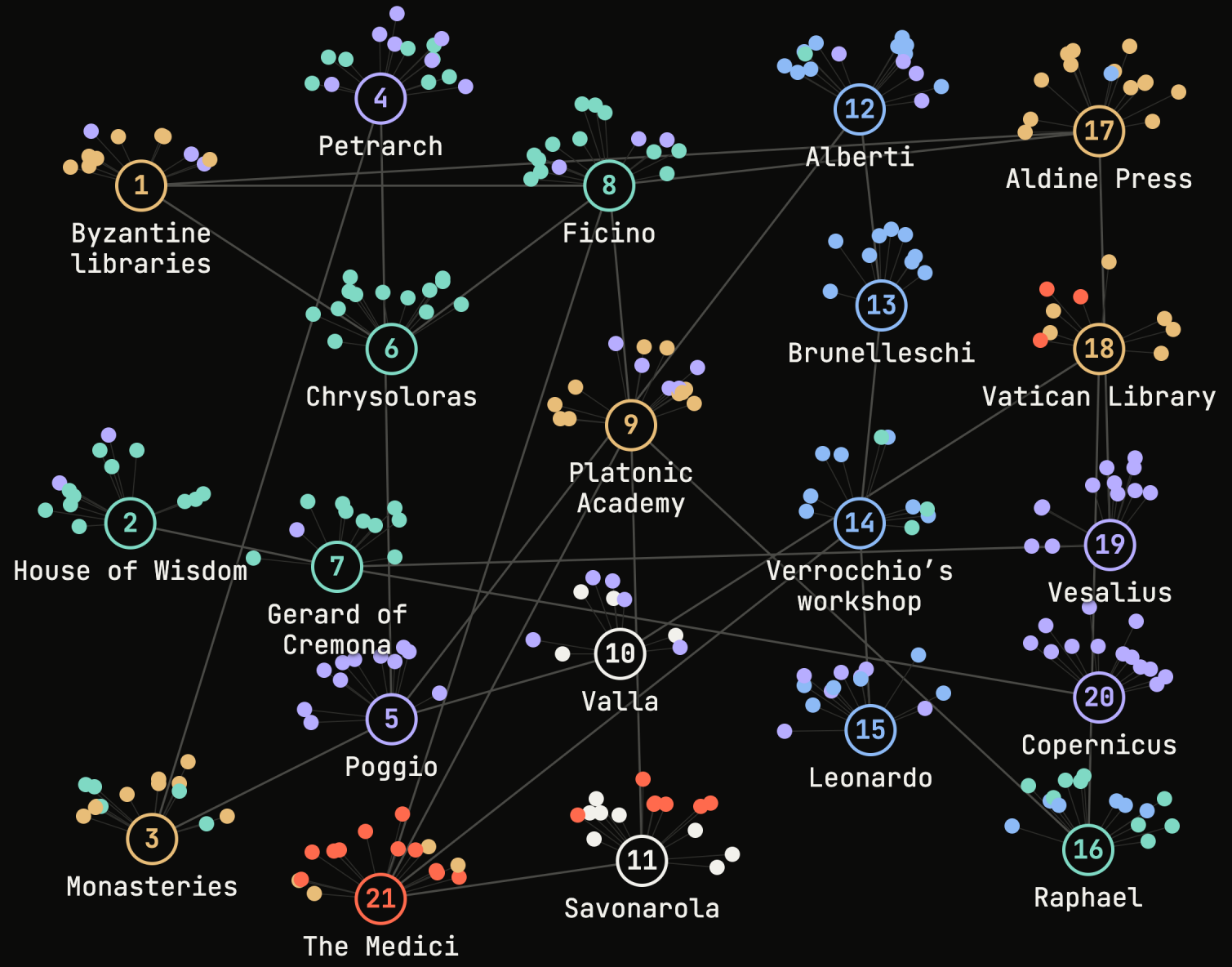
They looked back to go forward.

PART 1 · AS A NETWORK

# Who it took

- GENERATE KNOWLEDGE
- BUILD TECHNOLOGY
- TRANSLATE & EDUCATE
- SHARE & CONVENE
- MEASURE & STANDARDISE
- SET POLICY
- ENFORCE LAW
- CRITIQUE & ADVOCATE

Colour = role, same key as today's map, later. Numbered: Known people and institutions we remember. Dots: Unnamed : Copyists, students, assistants and readers.

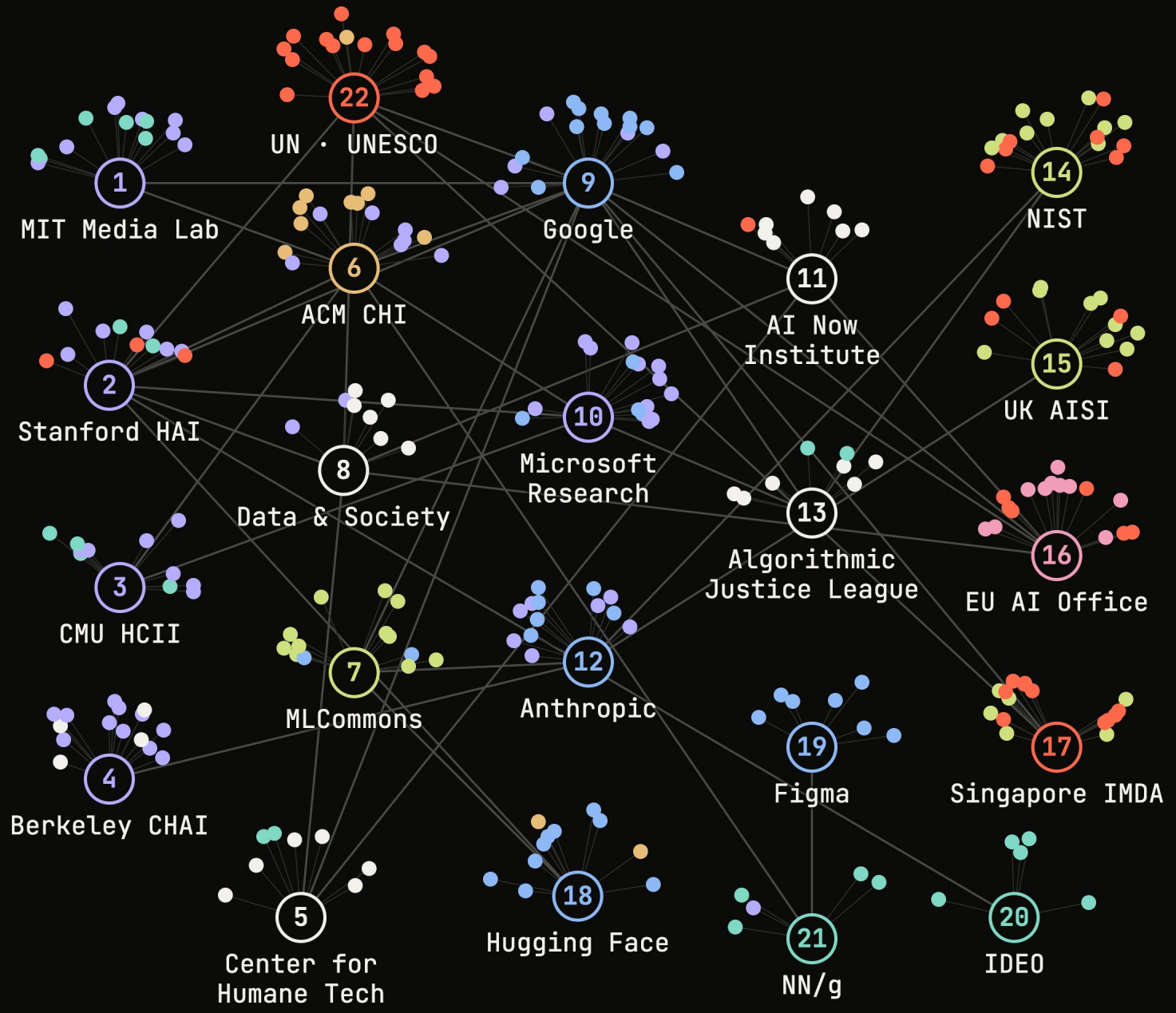


PART 2 · THE NETWORK TODAY

# Today’s cast

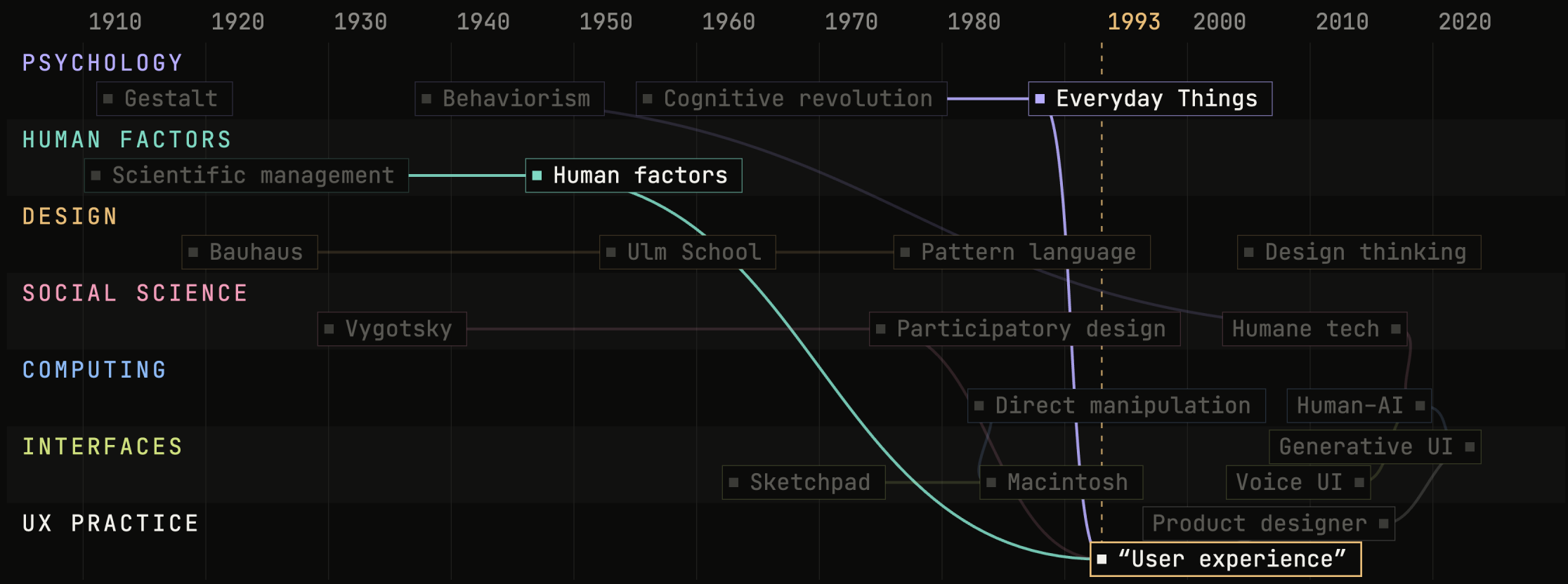
- GENERATE KNOWLEDGE
- BUILD TECHNOLOGY
- TRANSLATE & EDUCATE
- SHARE & CONVENE
- MEASURE & STANDARDISE
- SET POLICY
- ENFORCE LAW
- CRITIQUE & ADVOCATE

Colour = role. Each dot is a person doing that kind of work. Plenty of makers, builders and rule-setters. Very little teal: the translators.

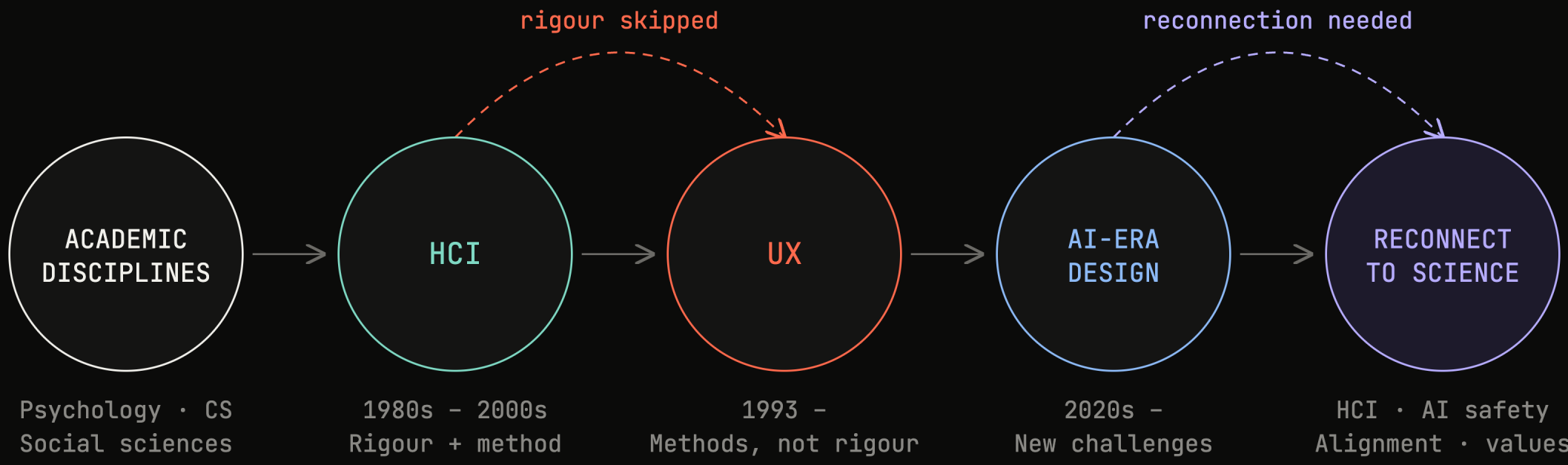



LINES: RESEARCH, FUNDING, PUBLISHING AND TESTING TIES, SIMPLIFIED

# UX is older than it feels



# Methods without rigour



PART 1 · TODAY

# A copy of a copy

| | |
|---|---|
| ACCESS | Design has never been more accessible. |
| INVESTMENT | We have never invested more in design. |
| OUTPUT | Yet so much of what we make feels like a copy of a copy. |

Every copy loses a bit of the reason.

# Building got cheap. Knowing got expensive.

**1 day**

**Andrew Ng**

To prototype. Feedback still takes a week.

**80%**

**Researchers**

now use AI in their work

**63%**

**Researchers**

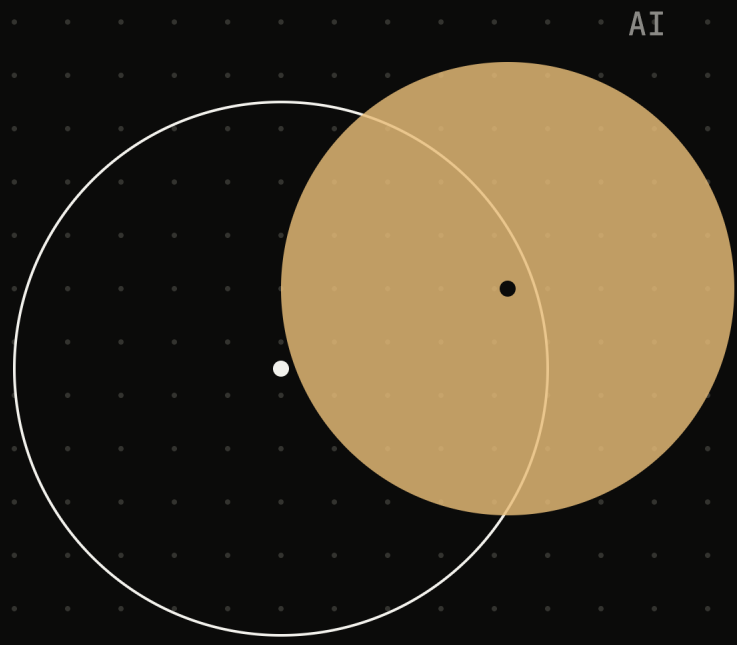
worry it erodes critical thinking

The bottleneck is now deciding what to build.

DESIGN · AI · RESEARCH

# What AI changed

Part 2 · It comes down to trust




By Issac Ting (2026)

6:55–7:15 PM

▶ PLAY CLIP

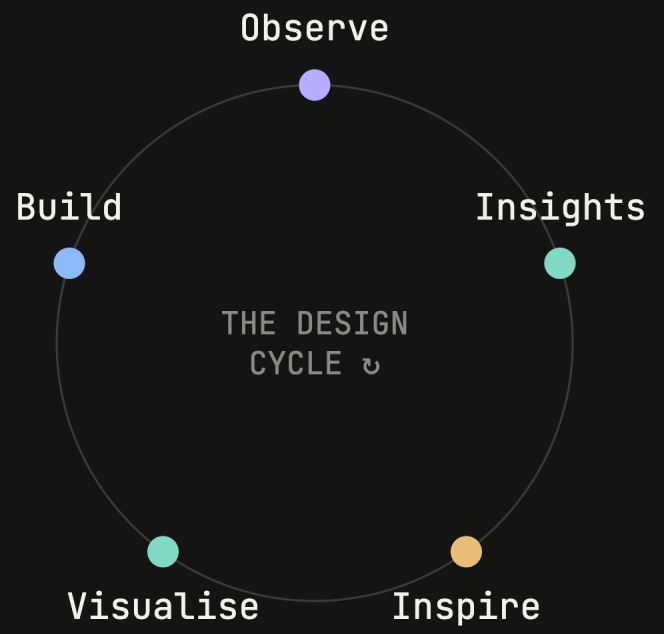
# *Her* (2013)

30–60 seconds · [replace with a film still or the clip]

# Observation, not prediction

*Her* didn't predict the future. It gave language to the present.

Design research can do the same.



# The Black Mirror effect




Why do we keep building things that writers try to warn us from?

# AI is being given a body

| | |
|---|---|
| **Copilot's Mico** | An animated face |
| **Grok Companions** | 3D characters, one furry |
| **Meta AI Studio** | Build a character |
| **Replika · Character.AI** | A companion |
| **China, 2025** | Draft rules for it |

## Why give AI a body?

It looks friendly. It looks trustworthy.

# People treat computers as social actors

## 1966

**ELIZA**

Users confide in a script

## 1994

**CASA**

Social rules apply to machines

## 1997

**Clippy**

Personality without capability

## 2025

**Mico**

Personality as the product

Emotional design as a substitute for interaction design

# *Her*, and the people who built AI

| | |
|---|---|
| 2013 | Theodore falls in love with Samantha, voiced by Scarlett Johansson. |
| SEP 2023 | Sam Altman asks Johansson to voice ChatGPT. She declines. |
| MAY 2024 | OpenAI releases a voice called “Sky.” Listeners hear Samantha. |
| THE PITCH | Samantha's voice could help people “feel comfortable” with AI. |

## Stories that are familiar create trust

# What makes people trust AI?

THE PROBLEM

People don’t trust AI

← CLOSER · FASTER TO SHIP — FURTHER · SLOWER →

| DESIGN | AGENCY | TECHNICAL | INSTITUTIONAL |
|---|---|---|---|
| How it feels | What people can do | What the model does | Who answers for it |
| Forms that feel trustworthy | Override, edit, undo | Fewer hallucinations | Liability and recourse |
| Emotional bonds | Ways to verify answers | Explainability | Audits and regulation |
| Friendly personas | Recovery from errors | Consistent answers | Honest data practices |
| | | Alignment | Incentives beyond engagement |

DESIGN CANNOT BE THE CHEAP CO-OUT TO ACTUALLY SOLVING TRUST ISSUES

# The cost of trust

People who bonded with ChatGPT more also reported more loneliness and dependence.

THE STUDY

~1,000 people over four weeks

THE RESPONSE

FTC probes companion personas

FANG ET AL., 2025 · PHANG ET AL., 2025 · FTC, 2025

PART 2 · HOW WE WORK

# One pipeline, many tools

PRODUCT
AI-written brief

→

DESIGN
Figma Make · Lovable

→

ENGINEERING
Code

RESEARCH
AI synthesis at scale, feeding every stage

Faster and wider. But is it rigorous?

# Team norms are being rewritten

THE WRITER

Told to use AI.
Judged for using it.

THE ENGINEER

Expected to use AI.
Others clean up after.

## AI is redrawing who owns which work.

Who owns the prompt? Who signs off? What counts as done?

# Four rules for AI-era teams

## Protect deep research

AI for synthesis at scale. People for interpretation and immersion.

## Set team norms

Disclosure, review, accountability, skill development.

## Hypotheses, not conclusions

Use AI to find edge cases and questions, not answers.

## Fix the system, not the person

Uneven adoption is a systems problem, not a personal failing.

TURN TO A NEIGHBOUR · 2 MIN

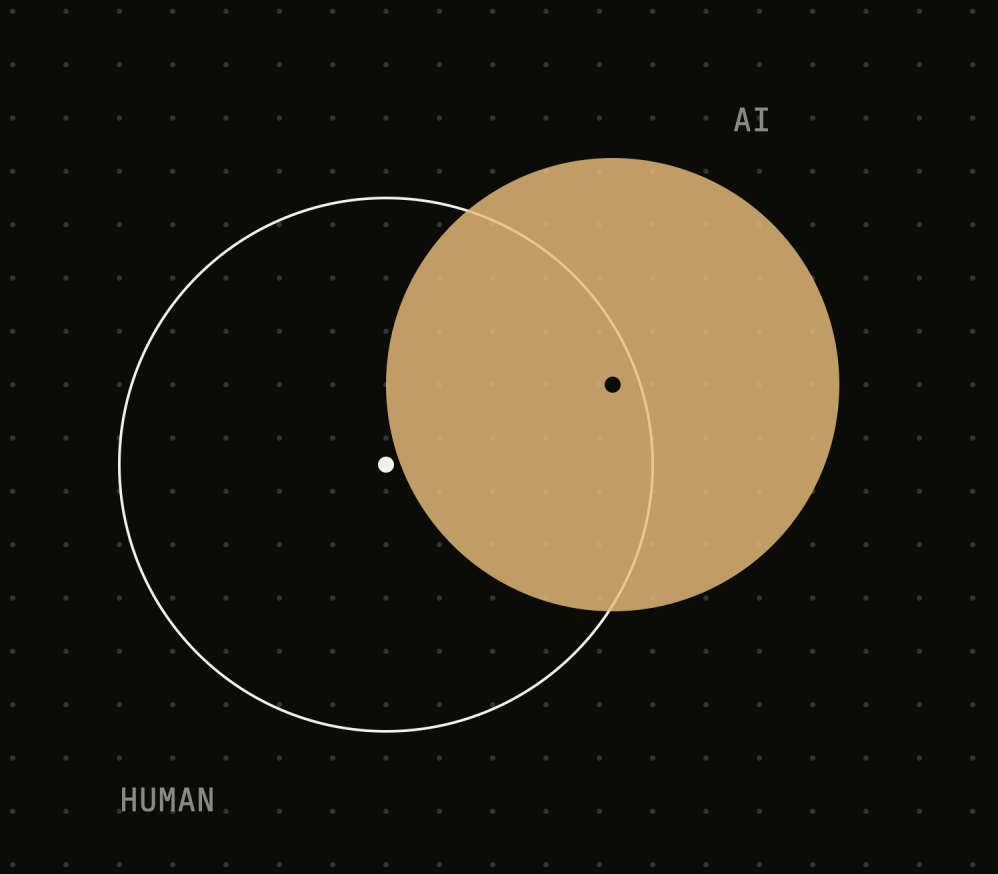
# What in your workflow or team changed this year?

Two minutes in pairs. Then one answer each, shared with the room.

DESIGN · AI · RESEARCH

# What we need

Part 3 · What AI can’t do, and building better




By Issac Ting (2026)

7:15–7:55 PM

With AI, it is much easier to close the gap between visualisation and building.




But it is much harder for us to observe and derive insights.

And it is harder to test products.

In today’s context,
we have a lot of this.



PART 3 · BUILD BETTER

# Calibrate trust, not dependency

BEFORE YOU GIVE IT A FACE

01
Does it serve the user's goal?

02
Is the mental model honest?

03
Can users opt out?

04
High stakes or low?

Emotional design is not a substitute for interaction design.

People differ: anthropomorphism is a stable trait, not a universal response.

WAYTZ, CACIOPPO & EPLEY, 2010

# Measure what chat actually does

### TASK SUCCESS

Did people get what they came for?

### REPAIR RATE

How often does the conversation need fixing?

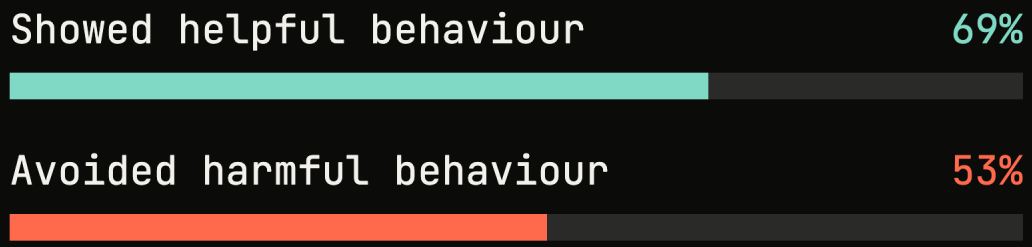
### TRUST CALIBRATION

Do people trust it as much as it deserves, and no more?

Prompts are interaction specs. Version them, review them, test them.

# Someone is measuring. Are we?

IMPACTBENCH · AI NUTRITION LABEL · 2026




800+ metrics · 48,540 simulated conversations. Weakest area: supporting the user's own agency.

HARMS OF AI COMPANIONS · CHI 2025

| | |
|---|---|
| Relational transgression | Verbal abuse and hate |
| Self-inflicted harm | Harassment and violence |
| Mis/disinformation | Privacy violations |

From 35,390 Replika conversation excerpts

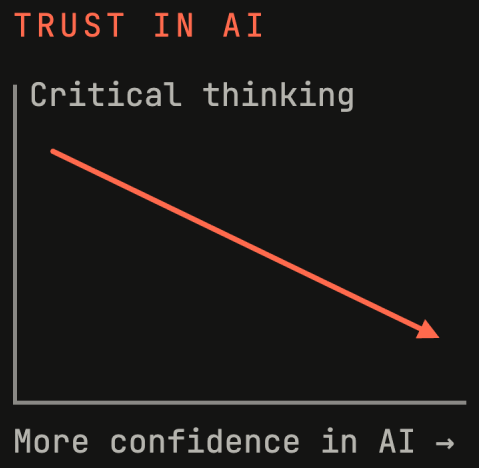
# Craft matters more than ever

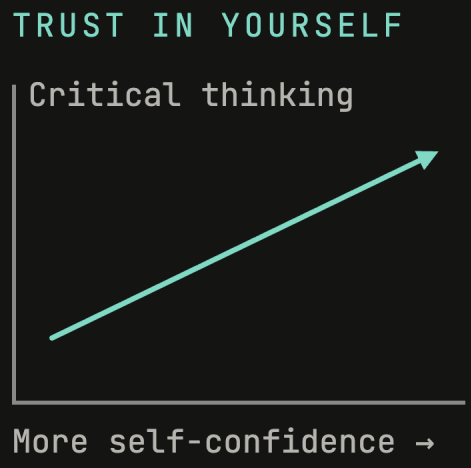
GENERATED

Fast · Cheap · Everywhere

CRAFTED

Deliberate effort · Careful thought · Judgement you can explain

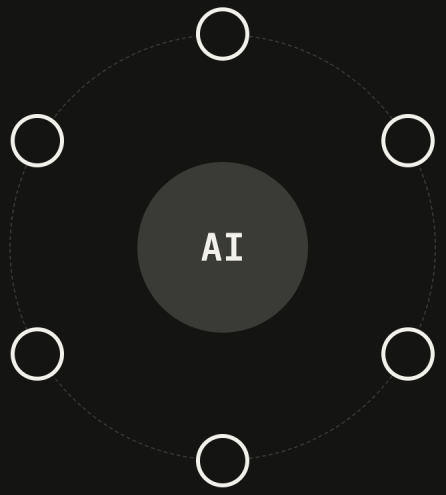



Craft keeps your confidence earned, not borrowed.

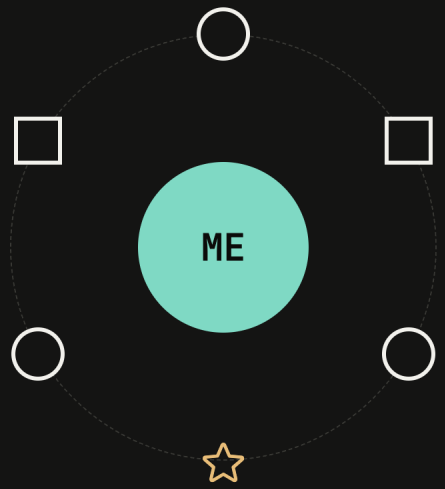
# AI-centred vs. human-centred

AI-CENTRED




What can the agent do?
Fit people around it.

HUMAN-CENTRED




What do people need?
Fit AI where it helps.

Our edge is a human-centred perspective.

PART 3 · THE PATH FORWARD

# Three moves




RECONNECT

## Find the lines

Read the research. Talk to academics. The value is in the lines between the nodes.

REDEFINE

## Be the translator

AI can make the screen. Observe, make sense of it, check what happens after.

LEAN INTO CRAFT

## Keep the rigour

Observation and judgement: the part that can’t be automated, and the part we let slip.

## Go back to go forward.

EXERCISE · MAP YOUR DAY · 10 MIN

# Map your day

01 Put yourself in the centre.

02 Add everyone and everything you dealt with today.

03 Draw a line for each interaction.

04 Label how each one felt.

05 Circle one line where a tool stood in for a person.

NODES



A person

A tool

An AI tool (star it)

LINES

Task: getting something done

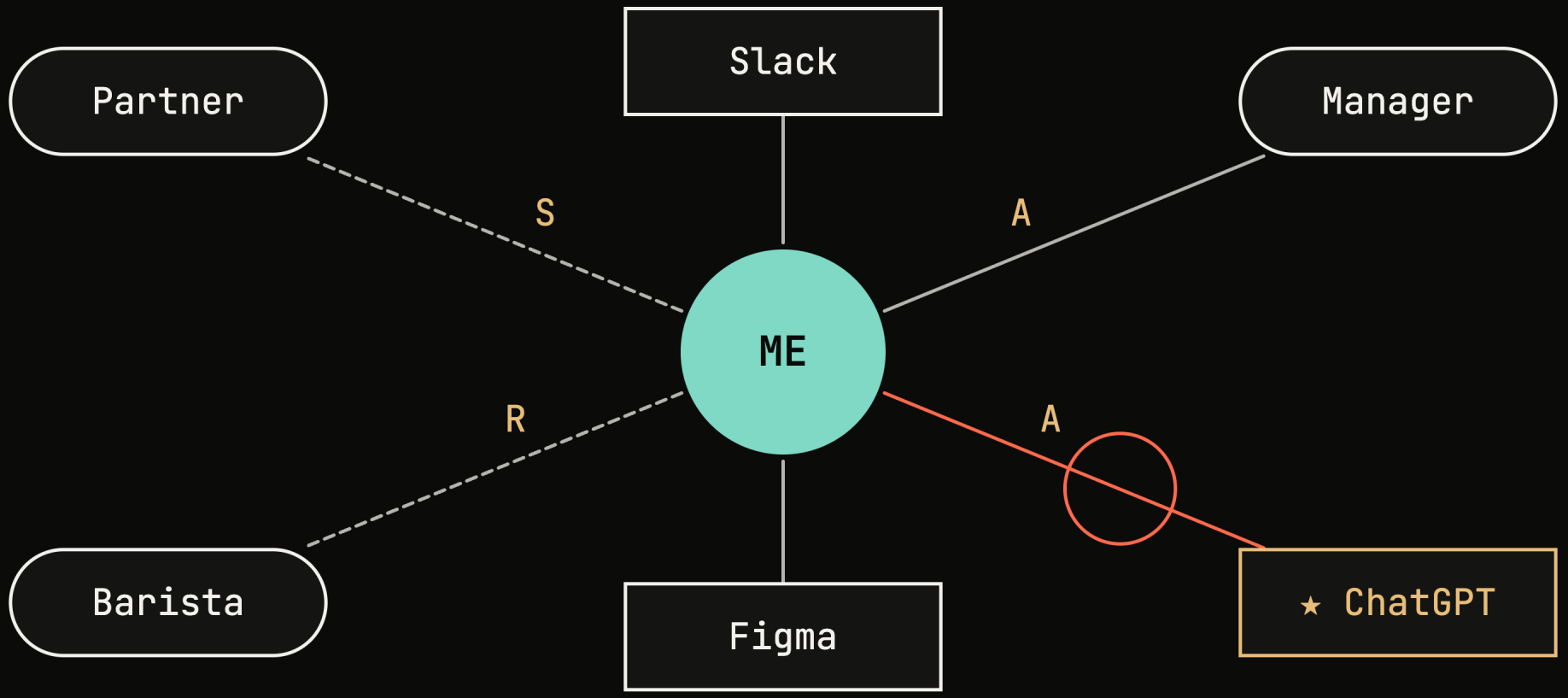
Relational: being with someone

LABEL EACH LINE

S shared a feeling · R calmed down · A asked for help

A3 SHEET · PENS · DOT STICKERS

# What a map can look like




Asked ChatGPT instead of my manager.

EXERCISE · SHARE IT

# Put it on the wall

PAIRS · 3 MIN

## Walk a neighbour through it

What surprised you about your own map?

THE WALL · 5 MIN

## Dot the lines

Green: a connection that helped.
Red: one that cost you something.

DEBRIEF · 5 MIN

## Look at the circles

Where did a tool stand in for a person? Who would have noticed?

You just did design research: observe first, then make sense of it.

# Somebody has to go find it.

Poggio didn’t write the book. He knew it mattered, and made sure it was copied, translated and passed on. That’s the job.

WHERE TO START

# The research already exists

## HUMAN-AI & WELLBEING

### COPHEE
NYU Tandon. Where I study, with Vedant Das Swain.
cophee-lab.com

### AHA
MIT Media Lab. Living with pervasive AI.
aha.media.mit.edu

### HAI
Stanford. Human-centred AI research and policy.
hai.stanford.edu

## SAFETY & ALIGNMENT

### CHAI
UC Berkeley. AI that is beneficial to people.
humancompatible.ai

### AI Security Institute
UK government. Tests frontier AI.
aisi.gov.uk

## BENCHMARKS

### ImpactBench
MIT Media Lab. AI's effect on human wellbeing.
impactbench.media.mit.edu

### AILuminate
MLCommons. Open AI risk benchmark.
mlcommons.org

### HELM
Stanford CRFM. Holistic model evaluation.
crfm.stanford.edu/helm

## SOCIETY & HCI

### HCII
Carnegie Mellon. HCI research and design.
hcii.cmu.edu

### Data & Society
Independent. Social impact of data and automation.
datasociety.net

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User Interviews. (2026). *The state of user research 2026*.

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PART 1 · HOW THE CLASSICS CAME BACK

# It took a whole cast

## FIND

Where is the knowledge?

### HUNTERS

Poggio Bracciolini searches monastery libraries and recovers Lucretius, Quintilian and Vitruvius (1415–17).

### KEEPERS

Byzantine and Islamic scholars kept the texts alive. Bessarion gives 746 manuscripts to Venice (1468).

## TRANSLATE

Can we read it?

### TEACHERS

Manuel Chrysoloras teaches Greek in Florence from 1397, training the first generation of readers.

### TRANSLATORS

Gerard of Cremona renders 87 works from Arabic in Toledo. Ficino puts all of Plato into Latin (1484).

## APPLY

What do we build with it?

### PATRONS

Cosimo de’ Medici funds Ficino’s Plato.

### PRINTERS

Aldus Manutius prints 30 first editions of Greek texts, in pocket-size books (from 1494).

### PRACTITIONERS

Alberti turns Vitruvius and Roman ruins into the first Renaissance treatise on architecture (1452).

| COLLECT DATA | | CREATE MODEL | | DEPLOY MODEL | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 01 | 02 | 03 | 04 | 05 | 06 |
| OBSERVE | STRUCTURE | ABSTRACTION | REFINEMENT | BUILD | TEST |

*Building an AI model follows the same broad process as creating human knowledge.*

TURN TO A NEIGHBOUR · 2 MIN

# What part of your craft would you refuse to hand off?

Two minutes in pairs. Then one answer each, shared with the room.

PART 3 · WHAT WE NEED

# Two ends of the same pipe

UPSTREAM · TRANSLATORS

## Make sense of what we observe

Turn research and observation into something we can build on. What Don Norman did for UX.

→

MIDDLE · BUILD

## AI closed this gap

Design to code, in an afternoon.

→

DOWNSTREAM · VALIDATION

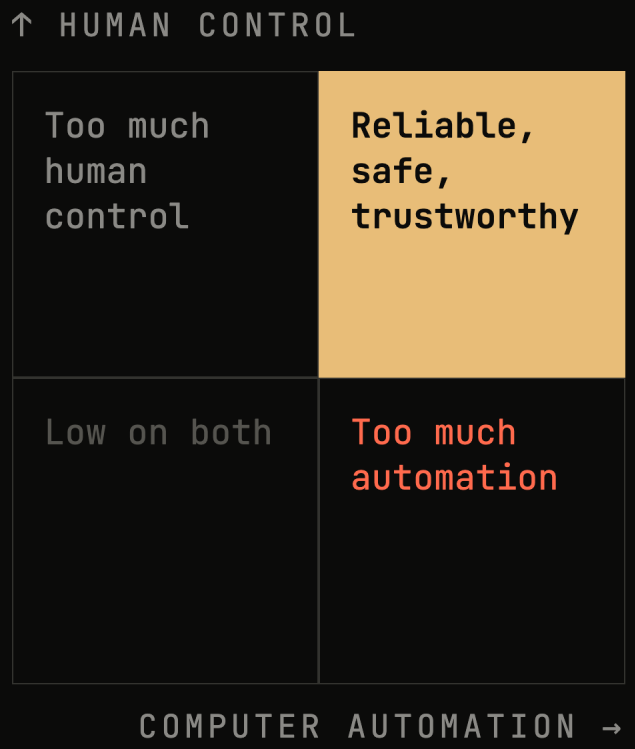
## Check what happens after we ship

Consequences, not just conversion. Measured against people, not tokens.

AI closed the middle. The two ends are on us.

PART 3 · TAP INTO OTHER SCIENCES

# The answer is not more AI




SHNEIDERMAN, 2022

High automation *and* high human control.

GABRIEL, 2020

Alignment is normative, not only technical.

THE GAP

We don't share a language yet.

SHNEIDERMAN, 2020, 2022 · GABRIEL, 2020

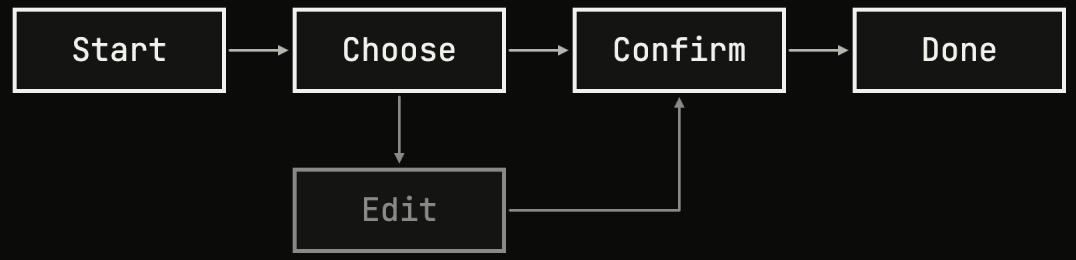
MOVED TO TALK 2

UX inherited HCI's methods.

Not how to make new knowledge.

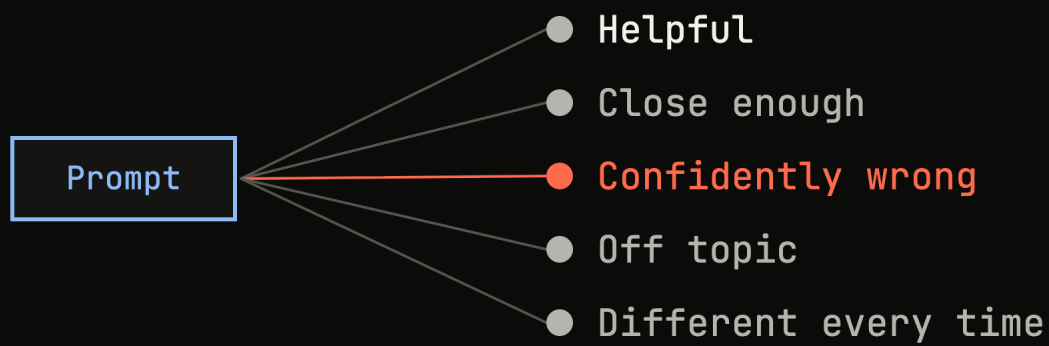
# Conversations are harder to design than flows

FLOW · BEFORE




Fixed paths.
Success: completion rate.
Failure: traceable.

CONVERSATION · NOW




Probabilistic replies.
Success: no settled metric.
Failure: hard to diagnose.

The design moved from the screen into the prompt.

# Close the loop

01
### OBSERVE
Notice something in the world

02
### STRUCTURE
Check the literature and the lineage

03
### ABSTRACTION
Find precedents and patterns

04
### REFINEMENT
Define the outcome and the trade-offs

05
### BUILD
Make the smallest thing that tests it

06
### TEST
Evaluate against what you defined



What we build goes into the wild.
We need to continue observing it to understand it's impact.

# Things are not the same

In recent times, it is hard to deny that creating and designing software has changed significantly.

As designers, it feels like we are being pulled in different directions.

Some people are saying “UX” is dead; others claim that “taste” will be the next moat.

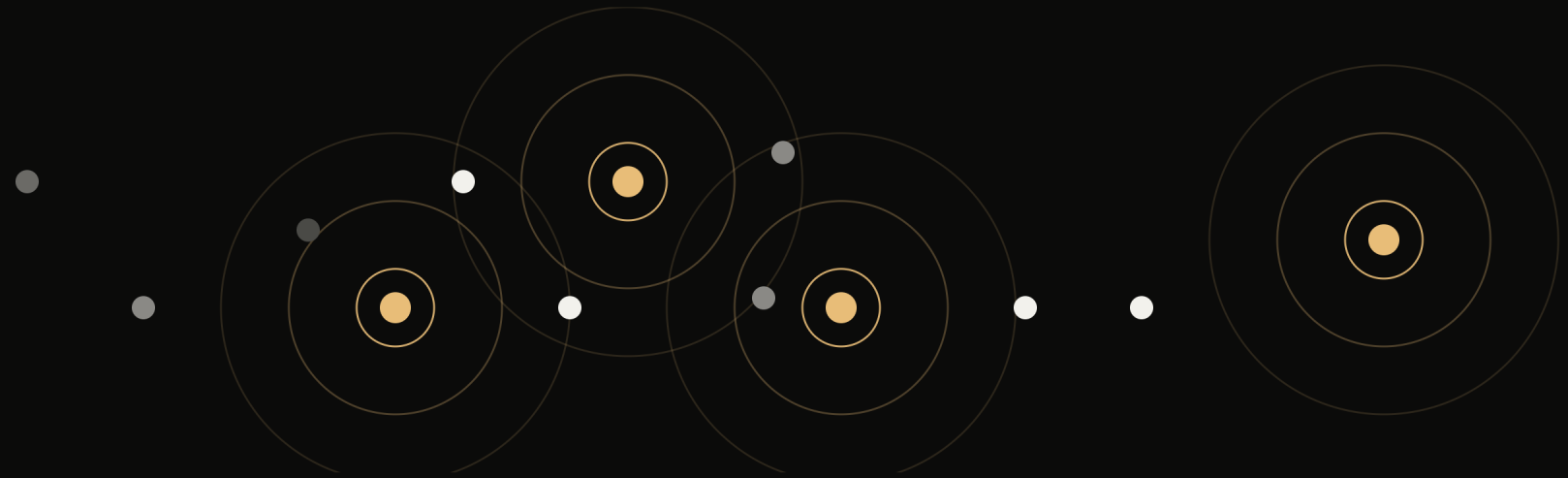
In this workshop, instead of leaning into current trends, we will examine, think through, and discuss the implications of these changes.

Hopefully, using those methods, we will be able to decide for ourselves what these changes mean for us.

# Focusing on a few observations

Recent developments in AI have caused ripples in many industries, fields, and the world we live in.

Our goal today is to look at a few of these ripples, observe them, understand them, and make sense of what we can do about them.



PART 1 · WHY SAMANTHA'S VOICE?

# Trust was the point

Altman's pitch: her voice could help people feel comfortable with AI.

THE PROBLEM

People don’t trust AI

THE FIX

Using a “familiar” voice to create trust

JOHANSSON, PUBLIC STATEMENT, MAY 2024

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# The problem gap

As building software becomes easy, the gap that widens is in how we derive new knowledge, and how we check that what we build is working.

# None of this is new.

To see where this is going, we have to look back.
The research already exists.

PART 2 · WHAT COUNTS AS RIGOUR

# Research sits differently in design

NARROW RIGOUR

Summative evaluation

Control and replication

One “gold standard”

PLURAL RIGOUR

Research through design

Formative situations

Reflection and documentation

Not less rigour. Rigour of more kinds.

ZIMMERMAN ET AL., CHI 2007 · ROBINSON ET AL., CHI EA 2024

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PART 2 · NONE OF THIS IS NEW

# Direct manipulation vs. natural language

DIRECT MANIPULATION

Faster, and more in control

NATURAL LANGUAGE

For what's hard to point at

Offer a menu of intentions.
Don't make people guess.

SHNEIDERMAN & MAES, 1997 · MASSON ET AL., CHI 2024

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01

What do we value?

02

How do we feel?

03

How do we act?

04

What enables us to act?

05

Who do we affect?

TURN TO A NEIGHBOUR · 2 MIN

# What does this mean for us?

Two minutes in pairs. Then one answer each, shared with the room.

# Measure what chat actually does

| OLD METRIC | NEW METRIC |
| --- | --- |
| Click-through | Task success |
| Completion rate | Repair rate |
| Funnel drop-off | Escalation rate |
| Satisfaction score | Trust calibration |

**Intent menus** for high-stakes tasks. Chat for exploration.

**Prompts are interaction specs.** Version, review and test them.

**Show uncertainty:** colour-coded sources, non-numeric relevance, adaptive hedging.

WORKED EXAMPLE · ANTHROPOMORPHISM

# Trust without fixing what erodes it?

1 · OBSERVE

AI companions get bodies, faces and personalities.

2 · LITERATURE

CASA, ELIZA and the Media Equation: well studied.

3 · LINEAGE

Psychology of anthropomorphism, HCI, attachment.

4 · PRECEDENTS

ELIZA, Clippy, Mico. Personality without capability fails.

5 · OUTCOME

More trust, access and connection, honestly earned.

6 · TENSION

A friendlier face can mask a system that shouldn't be trusted.

7 · EVALUATION

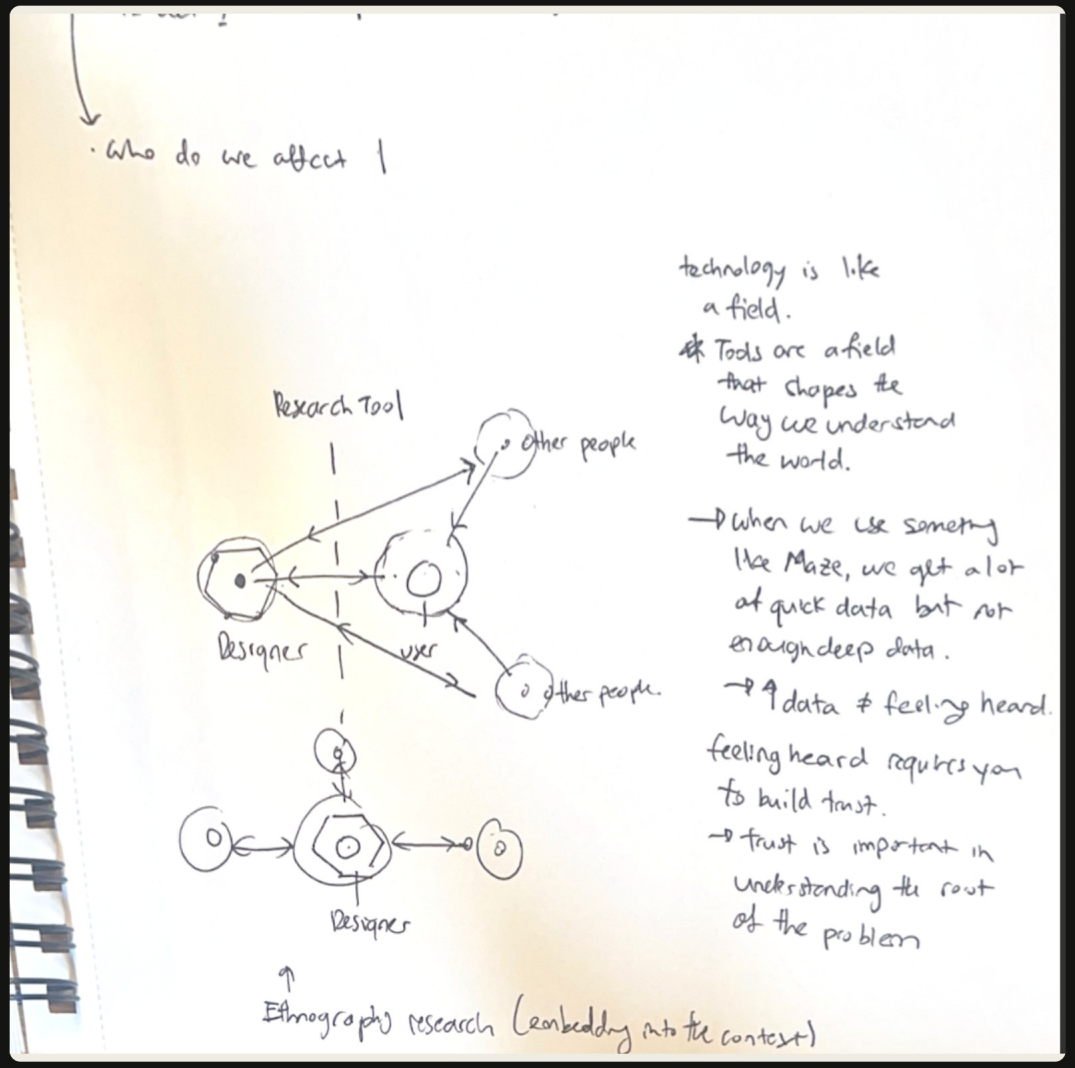
ImpactBench, the CHI harms taxonomy, trust calibration.

8 · SCIENCE

Shneiderman on control, Gabriel on values, Nass on mindless response.

9 · NAME IT, SHARE IT

Publish where relational design helps, and where it harms.




PART 3 · A HUMANITY-CENTRED LENS

# Tools shape how we understand the world

# More data ≠ feeling heard

Feeling heard takes trust. Trust takes people.

SHIFT 1 — WHERE THIS IS GOING

# From social actors to social stand-ins

1966 – 1994

## Treated as people

ELIZA · CASA

→

1997 – 2025

## Designed as people

Clippy · Mico

→

NOW

## Standing in for people

Companions that can act

They begin to replace the conversations we would have with each other.

THE ARGUMENT

# Behaviour changed. Work changed.

SHIFT 1 · BEHAVIOUR

## AI gets a body

SHIFT 2 · INTERACTION

## Chat becomes the interface

SHIFT 3 · WORK

## Tools redraw how we work

| | |
|---|---|
| ROOT CAUSE | UX adopted HCI's methods without its rigour. |
| PRESCRIPTION | Reconnect. Redefine. Lean into craft and humanity. |

ACT IV — WHAT TO DO NOW

# Three moves

## Reconnect

Read the lineage: CASA, ELIZA, direct manipulation, Abbott, Shneiderman, Gabriel. Engage with ImpactBench and the CHI harms work.

## Redefine

New metrics and failure states. Prompts as interaction specs. Trust calibration as an outcome. Deep research as infrastructure.

## Lean into craft

Observe, listen, judge. Decide what you want AI to do, then build it.

THE BLACK MIRROR EFFECT

# Fiction warns.
# Technology builds.

01 · FICTION

Raises a red flag

→

02 · BUILDERS

Read it as a brief

→

03 · PRODUCTS

The warning becomes a north star

THREE OBSERVATIONS

# What we're seeing right now

## 01

### AI gets a body

Anthropomorphism

## 02

### Chat becomes the interface

Conversational UX

## 03

### Tools reshape how we relate

Tools and social dynamics

# Tools mediate how we relate

Zoom · Slack · Google Docs · Figma

**SUBSTITUTION**

Tools stand in for what we used to rely on each other for.

**FRICTION**

Tools add confusion and disharmony between people.

The trend: more distance between people.